

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, plenty of clouds, rain and drizzle, high 40. **Tonight**, mainly cloudy, dry, low 38. **Tomorrow**, clouds early, some afternoon sun, dry, high 47. Weather map, Page A17.

VOL. CLXXV No. 60,801

© 2026 The New York Times Company

FRIDAY, FEBRUARY 20, 2026

Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00

U.S. HAS MILITARY READY FOR OPTION OF STRIKING IRAN

AMASSED IN MIDEAST

Trump Has Not Signaled a Decision on Force Over Diplomacy

This article is by **Helene Cooper**, **Eric Schmitt** and **Ronen Bergman**.

WASHINGTON — The rapid buildup of U.S. forces in the Middle East has progressed to the point that President Trump has the option to take military action against Iran as soon as this weekend, administration and Pentagon officials said, leaving the White House with high-stakes choices about pursuing diplomacy or war.

Mr. Trump has given no indication that he has made a decision about how to proceed. But the drive to assemble a military force capable of striking Iran’s nuclear program and its ballistic missiles and accompanying launch sites has continued this week despite indirect talks between the two nations on Tuesday, with Iran seeking two weeks to come back with fleshed-out proposals for a diplomatic resolution.

Mr. Trump has repeatedly demanded that Iran give up its nuclear program, including agreeing not to enrich any more uranium. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel, whose country would potentially take part in an attack, has been pushing for action to weaken Iran’s ability to launch missiles at Israel.

Israeli forces, which have been on heightened alert for weeks, have been making more preparations for a possible war, and a meeting of Israel’s security cabinet was moved to Sunday from Thursday, according to two Israeli defense officials.

Many administration officials have expressed skepticism about the prospects of reaching a diplomatic deal with Tehran. The indirect talks on Tuesday in Geneva ended with what Iran’s foreign

Continued on Page A9



JONATHAN KLEIN/AFP — GETTY IMAGES
The aircraft carrier Ford. It is now joining the Mideast fleet.

Barrage of Bills in G.O.P. States Seeks Vast Transgender Limits

By **AMY HARMON**

After a year in which the Trump administration has pressed to limit the ways Americans can identify as transgender in public life, Republicans are pushing the issue at the state level with new zeal.

With legislative sessions underway in most states, hundreds of bills restricting transgender rights are under consideration as social conservatives seek to capitalize on Trump administration tailwinds and a shift in public opinion to codify an understanding of sex and gender as binary and fixed.

In Kansas, lawmakers voted on Wednesday to invalidate the driver’s licenses of transgender residents who changed the gender markers on their licenses under a state policy that started allowing such changes almost

Tensions Rise Between U.S. And Anthropic

Feud Over A.I. Safety in Battlefield Use

By **SHEERA FRENKEL**
and **JULIAN E. BARNES**

SAN FRANCISCO — For months, the Department of Defense and the artificial intelligence company Anthropic have been negotiating a contract over the use of A.I. on classified systems by the Pentagon.

This week, those discussions erupted in a war of words.

On Monday, a person close to Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth told Axios that the Pentagon was “close” to declaring the start-up a “supply chain risk,” a move that would sever ties between the company and the U.S. military. Anthropic was caught off guard and internally scrambled to pinpoint what had set off the department, two people with knowledge of the company said.

At the heart of the fight is how A.I. will be used in future battlefields. Anthropic told defense officials that it did not want its A.I. used for mass surveillance of Americans or deployed in autonomous weapons that had no humans in the loop, two people involved in the discussions said.

But Mr. Hegseth and others in the Pentagon were furious that Anthropic would resist the military’s using A.I. as it saw fit, current and former officials briefed on the discussions said. As tensions escalated, the Department of Defense accused the San Francisco-based company of catering to an elite, liberal work force by demanding additional protections.

The disagreement underlines how political the issue of A.I. has become in the Trump administration. President Trump and his advisers want to expand technology’s use, reducing export restrictions on A.I. chips and criticizing state regulations that could be perceived as inhibitors to A.I. development. But Anthropic’s chief executive, Dario Amodei, has long said A.I. needs strict limits around it to prevent it from potentially wrecking the world.

Emelia Probasco, a senior fellow at Georgetown’s Center for Security and Emerging Technology, said it was important that the relationship between the Pentagon and Anthropic not be doomed.

“There are war fighters using Anthropic for good and legitimate purposes, and ripping this out of their hands seems like a total disservice,” she said. “What the nation needs is both sides at the table discussing what can we do with this technology to make us safer.”

In a statement, Sean Parnell, the Pentagon spokesman, said the

Continued on Page A18

Former Prince Is Arrested After Epstein Revelations



CHRIS RADBURN/REUTERS

An officer at an entrance to Wood Farm on the royal family’s Sandringham Estate, where Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor was living.

Ex-South Korea Leader Gets Life in Martial Bid

By **CHOE SANG-HUN**

SEOUL — Former President Yoon Suk Yeol of South Korea was sentenced to life imprisonment on Thursday after being found guilty of masterminding an insurrection when he declared martial law in 2024, a move that plunged the country into a constitutional crisis.

Prosecutors had demanded a death sentence for Mr. Yoon, 65, who has been on trial since April on a series of criminal charges stemming from that short-lived martial law declaration. The judges at the Seoul Central Dis-

Spared Death Penalty for Masterminding an Insurrection

trict Court on Thursday ruled on the most serious of them: being the ringleader of an insurrection.

While sentencing Yoon to life imprisonment, presiding Judge Ji Gwi-yeon said that Mr. Yoon had “flouted legal procedures and resorted to violent means to try to incapacitate the National Assembly and undermine democratic norms.”

Judge Ji said that while Mr. Yoon deserved a harsh sentence, he took into account Mr. Yoon’s age and the fact that he had refrained from using lethal force during the period of martial law.

Mr. Yoon, who denied the charges against him, has a week to appeal the verdict and ruling.

Mr. Yoon declared martial law on the night of Dec. 3, 2024, saying it was necessary to eliminate what he called “anti-state forces” within the opposition-dominated National Assembly. He called the legislature a “den of criminals” who he said used their parliamentary majority power to paralyze his

Continued on Page A5



DOUG MILLS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Red, White, Blue and Gold

The U.S. beat Canada in the Olympic women’s hockey final on an overtime goal by Megan Keller (5).

They Trade Agony for a Few Inches of Stature

By **ISABELLA KWAI**

Aaron Trinh was 5-foot-6, and he was unhappy.

His height was something he dwelled on constantly. In public, Mr. Trinh, 25, mentally measured himself against others. And it seemed that he was always looking up.

“I just didn’t want to be that person sticking out in a negative

Height Surgery’s Risks Make It Contentious

way,” he said. “I just had to get this out of my head.”

Then, two years ago, he came across some videos on TikTok about height surgery, a procedure in which the leg bones are frac-

tured and implanted with devices that slowly stretch them over several months, resulting in longer legs.

Limb-lengthening has been practiced by orthopedic surgeons for decades as a means of correcting deformities or length discrepancies. But in height surgery, also called stature-lengthening, it can be used for patients who wish to

Continued on Page A19



NATIONAL A10-19

After Avalanche, Devastation

As details began to emerge about the people killed in California, family members mourned the victims.

PAGE A18

Heated Visa Debate in Texas

Racist talk against South Asians has overshadowed a dispute over H-1B visas’ effect on U.S. workers.

PAGE A12

INTERNATIONAL A4-9

Detour for Trump Peace Board

President Trump hailed aid to Gaza but flouted protocol to back Viktor Orban’s bid to keep leading Hungary.

PAGE A9

Dreams of Autonomy Dashed

The Syrian Army’s advance into Kurdish regions is leaving ethnic Kurds wary, resistant and resigned.

PAGE A6

SPORTS B7-12

Detroit’s Pair of Aces

Tarik Skubal and Justin Verlander have become inextricably linked, two Tigers pitchers who have captivated crowds and won major awards.

PAGE B12



BUSINESS B1-6

Trade Deficit in Goods Is Up

Despite a record-high imports imbalance, the deficit narrowed overall because of a surplus in services.

PAGE B1

Pitfalls of Personalized Internet

The addition of A.I. in popular apps raises issues about what’s at stake. The answer: digital advertising.

PAGE B1

OBITUARIES A20-21

Nashville Hit Maker

Jerry Kennedy, 85, a guitarist and record producer, played a crucial role in creating major hit records by popular singers like Roger Miller, Roy Orbison and Tammy Wynette.

PAGE A21

Debonair Diplomat and Spy

Frederick Vreeland, the son of the influential fashion editor Diana Vreeland, had an upbringing well suited to his overt and covert duties during the Cold War. He was 98.

PAGE A20

OPINION A22-23

Nicole Gelinas

PAGE A23



WEEKEND ARTS C1-8

Overlooked Genocide’s Horrors

Cejla Stojka, whose art captures the trauma of the Roma people in the Holocaust, and their bucolic life beforehand, is the subject of a stirring show.

PAGE C1



0 354613 9